

December 2025 Edition

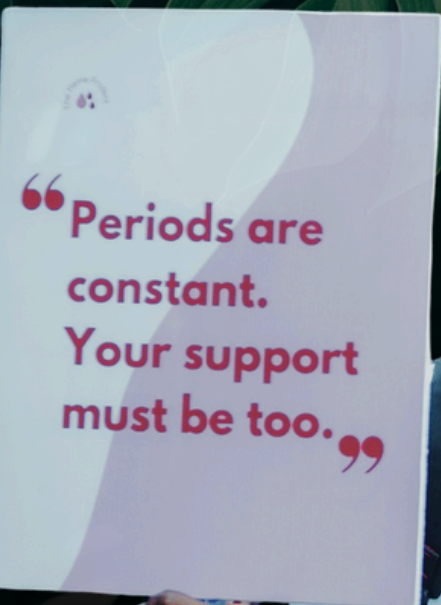
AUNUA

EMPOWERING HER

Changing the story for
women, the planet,
and the future.

THE HIDDEN STRUGGLE

Period Poverty: A Global Call for
Dignity and Change



PERIOD POVERTY
DEMANDS
ACTION,
AWARENESS,
AND
ACCOUNTABILITY.



One in two girls experiences menstrual poverty

Half of Our Girls Are Affected



Period poverty in Ireland is not a distant or isolated issue. Research and reports show that nearly 50 percent of girls have experienced some form of menstrual poverty. This includes struggling to afford period products, missing school days, or using unsuitable alternatives because there is no other choice. In practical terms, this means that in almost every classroom, there are girls quietly carrying a burden they should never have to bear.

For some girls, period poverty looks like staying home from school when their period arrives. For others, it means avoiding sports, school trips, or social activities. Over time, these interruptions affect confidence, participation, and academic engagement. What begins as a monthly challenge can grow into a long-term barrier.

ANUA starts by naming this reality honestly. Period poverty is not about personal failure. It is about access, dignity, and equality. If girls are expected to show up, learn, and succeed, then managing their period safely must be treated as a basic educational need, not an afterthought.

> THE PERIOD DIGNITY CRISIS

WHEN ACCESS BECOMES A RIGHT

Periods are a natural part of life, yet for many girls in Ireland they remain a source of fear, shame, and disruption. Menstrual poverty affects far more than physical comfort. It impacts education, confidence, participation, and mental wellbeing. In classrooms across the country, girls are quietly missing school days, sitting out activities, or struggling through lessons without access to basic products.

This is not a problem limited to one community or income group. Menstrual poverty affects girls from low-income households, those living in temporary accommodation, and young people whose families are already under financial pressure. For many, the challenge is not knowing where to turn when help is needed.



FROM SILENCE TO SUPPORT

Across Ireland, change is beginning. Local councils have introduced free period products in public buildings such as libraries and community centres. Schools and colleges are increasingly recognised as key spaces where dignity and access must be guaranteed, not optional.

Providing free products is about more than supply. It is about sending a message. Menstruation is normal. Support is available. No one should be excluded from education or opportunity because of their period.

NEARLY 50 PERCENT OF GIRLS IN IRELAND HAVE EXPERIENCED SOME FORM OF MENSTRUAL POVERTY, ACCORDING TO NATIONAL AND EUROPEAN RESEARCH.

ONE IN TWO GIRLS EXPERIENCES MENSTRUAL POVERTY

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

Menstrual poverty does not always look dramatic. Often it appears as absence. A missed day of school. A skipped sports class. A young person choosing silence over asking for help. Over time, these small moments add up, shaping how a girl sees herself and her place in the world.

When access to period products is unreliable, education becomes uneven. Confidence begins to slip. Shame fills the gaps where support should exist.



THIS IS WHERE CHANGE BEGINS

When girls are supported consistently and without judgement, they show up differently. They attend school. They participate fully. They move through their day without fear or distraction. Access creates confidence, and confidence creates opportunity.

This is why period dignity must be treated as a shared responsibility. One that belongs in schools, youth centres, and public spaces. One that ensures every girl has what she needs to learn, grow, and thrive.

MOST PERIOD PRODUCTS CONTAIN UP TO 90% PLASTIC

Conventional period products can take hundreds of years to break down, quietly contributing to long-term environmental damage.

Period poverty is often discussed as an issue of access, but another reality is rarely spoken about. Most traditional period products contain large amounts of plastic, leaving an environmental footprint that lasts far beyond a single month. For young people growing up in a climate crisis, this matters. Dignity should not come with long-term damage to the planet.

A Different Kind of Solution

Communities are increasingly recognising that period dignity and sustainability must be addressed together. Providing free products matters, but so does the type of product provided. Biodegradable alternatives offer a more responsible path forward, supporting girls and women while reducing long-term waste. This shift allows schools, youth centres, and public spaces to meet real needs without adding to a growing environmental burden.

AUNUA's Role

AUNUA's mission is to support communities in moving toward period products that are fully biodegradable, alongside education that breaks stigma and builds awareness. The aim is to help bring practical resources into learning and community spaces in a way that protects dignity today and reduces environmental harm for tomorrow.

Education Through Action

When menstrual education is paired with climate awareness, young people move from managing a challenge to understanding a wider responsibility. They learn to care for their bodies without shame and to think critically about waste, sustainability, and everyday choices. Over time, this creates a culture where support is normal, access is consistent, and caring for the planet becomes part of daily life.



FEATURING

FUTURE A GIRL

A RISING MOVEMENT FROM KAMPALA THAT IS REWRITING A GIRL'S STORY



How is the future changing?

There are places in the world where a girl's biggest dreams begin quietly. Sometimes they start in a small classroom. Sometimes in a crowded village. Sometimes in a moment of courage that no one else sees. In Uganda, inside the busy heartbeat of Kampala, one organisation has decided to catch these small sparks before they disappear. It is called Future A Girl, and its mission is simple. Help a girl believe she can shape her life, then walk with her as she does it.

Future A Girl is a growing movement in Kampala, built on community and compassion. Many girls there face real challenges, from dropped education to poverty to early motherhood.

Future AGirl focuses on building quiet, lasting confidence in every girl. Their work spans in many fields - education, community development, counselling, sports, nutrition and skill building, all shaped by one belief. When a girl feels supported, her world opens wide. A core part of their mission is the Learning and Care Hub, a safe space for teenage and under age mothers. Here they are not judged but guided, encouraged and taught skills that help them rebuild their lives. Many arrive overwhelmed, yet leave with dignity, hope and a renewed sense of possibility they never thought they would fully regain again.



One of the most touching parts of their mission is the Learning and Care Hub. This is a safe space for teenage and under age mothers. It is a place where they are not judged or forgotten. Instead they are guided, encouraged and taught skills that help them rebuild their lives. Many of these young mothers arrive feeling overwhelmed, but they leave the hub with a sense of dignity and hope. It becomes a second chance they never imagined they would receive.

Future A Girl also works within communities because a girl does not grow alone. Her environment shapes her confidence. Her neighbours shape her opportunities. Her school shapes her dreams. The organisation works closely with families, teachers and local leaders to create a culture where girls are protected, supported and celebrated. This community driven approach is part of what makes their work feel organic and deeply rooted.

The organisation also builds impact through community awareness and outreach. Workshops, events, and conversations with families help shift attitudes and encourage stronger support for girls' education and well-being. By engaging parents, teachers, and local leaders, a wider circle of protection and understanding forms around each girl. This shared involvement helps positive change continue long after programmes end.

The Journey of Uganda's Brave Young Girls

Education is a core pillar of Future A Girl. When a girl learns, her world widens and she discovers new skills and choices. The organisation helps girls stay in school and build future ready abilities, while counselling services offer safe spaces to talk, heal and grow with confidence.

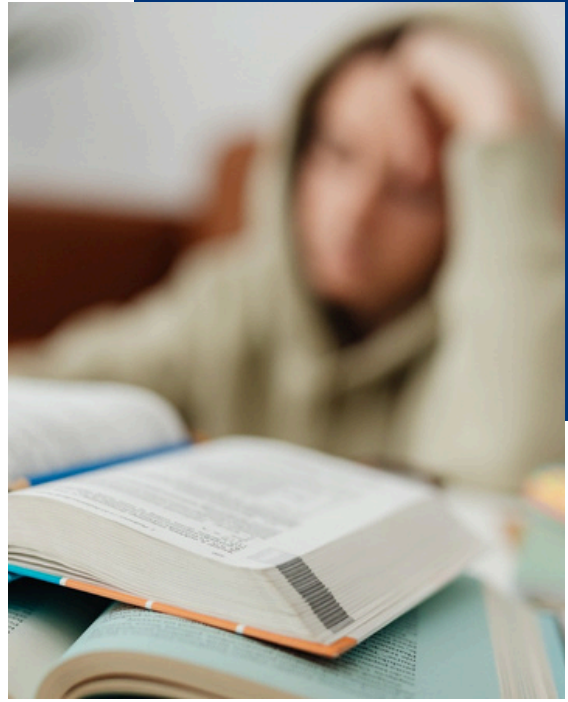
Change often begins in small moments. A counsellor offering comfort. A volunteer sharing a book. A coach encouraging a shy child. A mentor reminding a girl that her voice matters. These moments spark transformation.

What makes Future A Girl stand out is its vibrant, community driven spirit. The team understands the challenges girls face, and every programme carries empathy and purpose. Volunteers are passionate, the atmosphere is positive and the organisation continues to guide girls toward a stronger, more confident future.

Where Courage, Opportunity, and Healing Are Reshaping the Journey of Young Mothers.



A Lived Experience From Ireland



For many young people in Ireland, period poverty is not a statistic. It is a memory.

In a national survey of girls aged 12 to 19, nearly half reported struggling to afford basic period products. Some shared that when pads or tampons were out of reach, they were forced to improvise with tissue or other unsuitable materials just to get through the school day.

Student Caoimhe Dowling spoke about how this struggle continued into college. Buying period products became a source of stress, with essential items competing against food and transport when money was tight. Others, like student advocate Sheenagh Rowland, recall school days when friends had no option but to use tissue, managing their periods in silence and embarrassment.

These experiences affected more than comfort. They shaped confidence, participation, and wellbeing. The fear of being noticed, the effort to hide, and the anxiety of leakage followed many through their school years.

Period poverty is not only about access to products. It is about dignity and equality. And for many young people in Ireland, it remains a lived reality.

Youth Leading the Future: Inspiring the Next Generation



Building Confidence Through Leadership Opportunities

Today's youth are stepping forward with courage, creativity, and a deep desire to make a difference. They challenge outdated systems, raise their voices for justice, and embrace innovation as a tool for positive change. Aunua Global recognises the powerful role young people play in shaping a kinder, more equitable future. By giving them a platform to express their ideas and participate in meaningful projects, Aunua empowers them to become leaders with purpose.

The Power of Youth Voices in Social Change

Through leadership programmes and collaborative activities, young participants develop skills that help them navigate real-world challenges. They learn to articulate their ideas, work as a team, and harness their creativity to address social issues. These experiences show them that age does not limit influence and that their voices are strong enough to spark transformation. As they gain confidence, they begin to inspire others within their schools and communities.

The potential of youth leadership extends beyond individual growth. When young people feel empowered, they bring fresh perspectives into their communities and contribute to building a future shaped by empathy, equality, and innovation. Aunua helps guide these young changemakers as they explore their passions, develop new abilities, and discover the importance of using their voices responsibly. The world needs young leaders, and Aunua is committed to helping them rise.

Sustainability & Social Impact Building a Greener Tomorrow

How Environmental Awareness Creates Healthier, Stronger Communities

Environmental protection is no longer a distant concern; it is an urgent responsibility that affects the health and future of every community. Aunua Global's sustainability initiatives are grounded in the belief that caring for the planet is inseparable from caring for people.

Environmental challenges such as waste buildup, pollution, and resource scarcity directly impact the well-being of children and families, particularly in vulnerable regions. Aunua focuses on promoting sustainable practices that support both ecological balance and community health.

Much of this work involves educating communities about the importance of responsible waste management, eco-friendly alternatives, and the long-term effects of unsustainable living. By encouraging small but meaningful changes in everyday habits, Aunua helps families become more mindful of how their choices influence the environment. These efforts often include promoting biodegradable menstrual solutions, reducing single-use plastics, and teaching the value of reusing and recycling.

The most powerful impact of these initiatives is the sense of shared responsibility that begins to grow within communities. People develop a deeper connection to the planet and understand that protecting it is part of protecting their own future. Aunua's sustainability work inspires hope by demonstrating that environmental care and human dignity can move hand in hand. Through awareness, action, and collaboration, the organisation is helping to build a greener, healthier, and more compassionate tomorrow.



The Pad That Protects Girls and the Planet



Around the world, millions of girls struggle every month not because of their period, but because they lack safe, affordable, and sustainable menstrual care. At the same time, billions of used pads end up in landfills, rivers, and open environments often taking centuries to break down.

The GoPad initiative introduces a groundbreaking solution designed to address both problems at once. Created with biotransformation technology, GoPad looks and feels just like a standard pad but transforms safely in nature, leaving behind no microplastics, no toxins, and no harmful waste.

In many countries without proper waste-management systems, as much as 80% of sanitary waste ends up directly in the environment. Traditional pads, which are largely made from plastic, contribute heavily to long-term pollution. GoPad™ changes this narrative by using innovative materials that naturally break down into a harmless, wax-like substance within approximately two years.

Alongside its environmental benefits, GoPad plays a vital role in empowerment. Many girls miss school or daily activities due to lack of access to menstrual products. This initiative focuses on providing them with support, dignity, and the resources needed to stay in education. With every GoPad pack, Real Relief also offers simple and accessible educational materials helping young girls understand their bodies with confidence and care.

GoPad is not just a sanitary pad it is a step towards menstrual equity and environmental responsibility. By choosing GoPad, users support an initiative that prioritises the planet, uplifts young girls, and challenges outdated norms around menstrual health.

As awareness of sustainable living grows worldwide, eco-friendly solutions like GoPad are becoming essential. This initiative demonstrates that protecting the planet and empowering communities can go hand in hand.



AUNUA
VOICE FOR CHANGE